

Is It Gold?

Three things in your pan glitter. Only one of them is gold. Print this page, cut out the card, and keep it in your kit with your vial.

POCKET ID CARD • CUT ALONG THE DASHED LINE

Gold glows, bends, and stays put.

GOLD

Shade: still glows warm yellow in your shadow

Pin: soft. Dents or bends, never shatters

Pan swirl: heavy. Stays at the bottom, barely moves

Shape: flat flakes, rounded edges

Magnet: no

MICA

Shade: goes dull or silvery in shadow

Pin: flakes apart in thin sheets

Pan swirl: light. Floats and washes away first

Shape: paper-thin, flashes in sun

Magnet: no

PYRITE

Shade: brassy, pale, goes dull

Pin: hard and brittle. Crushes to a dark powder

Pan swirl: medium. Moves with the black sand

Shape: sharp edges, often little cubes

Magnet: no (but often found with magnetite)

Weight check: gold is about 19.3 g/cm³, roughly 7× heavier than sand. If it moves easily, it isn't gold.

✂

The three tests, step by step

1. The Shade Test (5 seconds)

Turn your back to the sun so your body shades the pan. Real gold keeps its warm, buttery color in the shade. Mica and pyrite need direct sunlight to sparkle and turn gray or pale in shadow.

2. The Pin Test (10 seconds)

Snuff the flake into your vial or onto a dry surface. Press it gently with the point of a sewing pin. Gold is soft and malleable: it dents, flattens, or bends. Pyrite is hard and brittle and crumbles. Mica splits into thinner sheets.

3. The Pan Test (30 seconds)

Put the flake back in a pan with a little water and black sand. Swirl slowly. Gold stays put while everything else drifts. Mica floats off almost immediately. Pyrite moves along with the black sand.

Other things that fool beginners

LOOKS LIKE GOLD	HOW TO TELL
Weathered mica ("cat's gold")	Golden-brown flakes that float and shatter under a pin
Brass or copper bits	Usually old trash: shell casings, wire. Green tint, sharp manufactured edges
Chalcopyrite	Brassy with a greenish or iridescent tarnish. Brittle like pyrite
Wet yellow sand	Dry it. Real gold doesn't change color when dry

Still not sure? Put it in your vial and bring it to a local GPAA chapter meeting or a rock shop. Prospectors love looking at a beginner's vial. Take a close-up photo through a magnifying glass too.

Ezra says: "Fool's gold shows off. Real gold just sits there and waits for you to notice."

From First Flake: Josie's 7-Trip Field Workbook. The three tests come from Trip 7. Not a substitute for a professional assay.